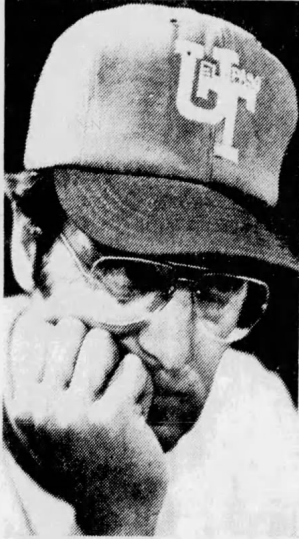


McFarlin sees positive things

UTEP baseball future bright



THEY SAY A picture is worth a 1,000 words. This picture pretty well reflects the type of season UTEP's baseball team had. Miner head coach Larry McFarlin, who handed in his resignation last Monday, looked a bit down in the dumps after his team had lost 20 consecutive WAC games including four straight to the New Mexico Lobos two weeks ago.

By JIM THOMAS

Despite losing nearly all of their Western Athletic Conference-South Division baseball games (1-22-1) and most of their games overall (22-29-1), former Miner head baseball coach Larry McFarlin still saw some positive things.

Unfortunately, he won't be around — at least not at the head job as he handed in his resignation Monday — next season to watch his first real recruited class continue.

"When I took over the program (he replaced long time coach Andy Cohen who retired) I knew I would be in for a big challenge but it was something I had to do," McFarlin explained. "The program at UTEP was down a bit and there was a lot of work to be done. Because I took over so late (towards the end of summer 1978) I couldn't really recruit. I had to go with what we had."

THE MINERS last season beat powerful Oklahoma University three out of four games, dropped top-five rated Wichita State and started off the WAC season with a win over San Diego State. The Miners then ran out of gas and lost their remaining 17 straight.

"I was able to recruit my first class after the season ended and I think we came up with some pretty good people. I went after pitching mostly and

picked up a few players," he said.

Those players went on to have a good season for the Miners and their demanding expanded schedule. The 1980 team set 11 school records and it was his new recruits which did a majority of the work. Newcomer Jimmy Walker, who transferred in from Mesa, Ariz., Junior College, established a new RBI mark of 50. But by the time the season had ended senior third baseman Mike Brooks reset the mark at 52. Ironically, McFarlin and his assistant Bob Alsup, held the record of 48 in 1967 and 1977, respectively.

JC transfer first baseman Tommy Thompson set the record for most triples with seven (Alsup and Charlie West '67 held the old standard of six). Outfielder Dan Haygood drew a record 41 walks.

Besides individual marks, several team records were set including most hits in a season (518; old mark 490 set in 1970); most at bats (1,678; old 1,556 in 1978); most home runs (38; old 31 in 1968); most doubles (95; old 31 in 1968); most team RBI (365; old 276 in 1976); most stolen bases (64; old 45 in 1978); most sacrifices (42; old 35 in 1978) and most times walked (275; old 219 in 1977).

THE MINERS this past season won 14 games during one stretch, which McFarlin said was the highlight. His team, though, lost its first 20 consecutive WAC games in a row until UTEP

dropped San Diego State this past weekend.

McFarlin said that all the new players he recruited said that they had learned things in playing major college baseball. He cited Thompson, freshman pitchers Monte Wren, Mike Maddux and Mike King, and Walker as possible stars next season. El Pasoan Pico Cordova, formerly of Burges, also was a pleasant surprise and should help more next season. He also cited reserve outfielder Rick Perez and reserve Art Flores also as strong candidates to see plenty of action next year.

"All the outfield will be back with plenty of experience," he said. "The infield will lose only Brooks and should be solid. And the pitching staff should be much improved."

McFarlin's resignation doesn't take effect until June 1. He still plans on doing some recruiting by phone, mail and limited personal contacts.

"I want to help who is ever the new coach as much as I can or he wants. Just because I'm stepping down doesn't mean I'm not going to support the program," McFarlin added.

McFarlin helped get UTEP's baseball program back on the right foot and he will be missed. He gave unselfishly to the school, even giving up his vacation to work on a practice field at the campus (the field will be torn up because the land will be used for a new business school building).

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